EU, CHINA: Hybrids deal won’t stop gradual EU trade policy tightening

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【要点】

・10月9日の合意により、EU は中国からのハイブリッド車輸入を2026年レベルの約半分に制限する予定で、12月から発効する見込み。

・この合意は欧州の産業過剰生産能力に関する懸念に対処しておらず、EUは今後、機械・化学などの新たなセクターへの関税・クォータ拡大を進める可能性が高い。

・EUは調達アクセスと政府補助金プログラムへの中国のアクセスを制限する法案も推進していく。

・中国がハイブリッド車の輸入上限を受け入れたのは、欧州との貿易紛争をさらに悪化させたくないという意向の表れ。

・セーフガード措置は第三国にも影響を与えるため、EUは他国との関係悪化を防ぐため、今後数ヶ月で個別の例外措置や大型クォータについて交渉する見通し。

【メール原文】

Agreement on hybrid vehicles is likely to cap future imports at around half of 2026 levels. During the 8-9 October ministerial meeting in Beijing, the

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Hybrids deal won’t stop gradual EU trade policy tightening

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A 9 October agreement on hybrid vehicle exports will cap future EU imports from China at around half of 2026 levels, but does little to address broader European concerns about industrial overcapacity and will not deter the EU from gradually tightening trade and industrial policies.
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The EU will likely extend tariffs and quotas to new sub-sectors (primarily in machinery and chemicals), barring more sectoral agreements in the coming months, while also moving forward with legislation to restrict China’s access to procurement and state aid programs.
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Beijing’s willingness to accept EU caps on hybrid vehicle imports reflects an acknowledgement of European trade concerns and an increased desire to avoid a more disruptive trade dispute with Brussels.

Agreement on hybrid vehicles is likely to cap future imports at around half of 2026 levels. During the 8-9 October ministerial meeting in Beijing, the two sides reached an agreement to let the EU cap imports of Chinese hybrid and plug-in hybrid vehicles (HEVs/PHEVs). Imports in this segment have

surged this year, while other car imports have stayed broadly flat since EV tariffs took effect in 2024.

Such a deal would cap imports at roughly half 2026 levels for the rest of the decade. As of July, HEV imports from China had already reached 380,000, far exceeding the total for 2025. Details have not been made official, but the deal will likely cap EU imports at around 350,000 per year, roughly half of 2026 levels, rising by 6% annually through 2030, and come into effect from December.

With Beijing's acquiescence, the cap will likely be implemented via EU trade safeguards like those already in place for steel. This is more practical than unilateral export restraint, which would be hard to reconcile with WTO rules and difficult to enforce on exporters.

The cap gives European automakers some oxygen but could raise tensions with other partners. It would stop Chinese automakers from gaining a further share of this segment in Europe, though European firms will likely keep losing ground in China and other markets, with the exception of the US.

Because EU safeguards apply across the board, they would also hit third countries, which would be assigned quotas; the steel safeguards and plans to restrict access to procurement and state aid have already strained ties with other partners. The EU will likely negotiate case-by-case exemptions or large quotas in the coming months, partly to guard against trade diversion from China (see EU: 'Made in Europe' agenda puts UK-EU trade relations at risk , 23 September 2026).

Brussels will still pursue a gradual tightening of trade and industrial policies. The agreement further reduces the risk of a full-blown trade war, but it will not stop the EU's plans to gradually tighten trade and industrial policies toward China in critical sectors. Hybrid vehicles accounted for less than 3% of the EU's ballooning €360 billion trade deficit with China last year. Last week's Trade and Investment Consultations (TIC) meeting did not address core EU grievances relating to large-scale Chinese government subsidies, industrial overcapacity, and China's undervalued exchange rate. Beijing is highly unlikely to make meaningful concessions on these issues, which it sees as integral to its growth strategy (please see EU-China: Trade confrontation will escalate despite managed pause , 7 July 2026).

New trade defences in additional sub-sectors are likely, barring more sectoral deals. A new meeting of the TIC is scheduled for January. Later this week, EU heads of state will likely give the European Commission a mandate to adopt new trade defense instruments pending the outcomes of the talks. Either China will agree to more negotiated quotas in additional sectors seeing export surges, or the EU will likely move forward with new restrictions—unilateral quotas or tariffs. Chemicals and machinery will be the main focus. Member states are also likely to discuss new instruments to complement the EU's limited toolkit, including an "EU Section 301." These are likely to move slowly, however, and are intended more to equip the EU to respond to retaliation than to enable sweeping, horizontal US-style levies (see EU: Dispatch from Brussels—Russia's hybrid war and China's overcapacity challenge , 1 October 2026).

Plans to restrict access to public procurement are likely to move ahead. The EU will also advance legislation restricting China's access to EU public procurement markets and state aid programs across automotive, clean tech, and metals (the Industrial Accelerator Act - IAA), as well as new restrictions on connected devices on cybersecurity grounds, mainly designed for China (the Cybersecurity Act - CSA). Disagreements in the European Council and Parliament concern the level of restrictions and

third-country access, not the principle. Spain's early elections in November will also likely remove one of the main China-friendly holdouts from the council, further shifting the balance in favor of more restrictions (see EU: 'Buy European' requirements will support derisking from China , 27 May 2026).

China's willingness to accept EU caps on hybrid imports shows openness to addressing trade concerns. Beijing had opposed voluntary export restraints as a WTO violation. In the end, however, China quietly agreed to the EU quota system because it does not target China directly, and it allows for hybrid vehicle imports meaningfully above 2025 levels, with modest room to grow. Despite earlier threats of retaliation, including via rare earth export curbs, Beijing now appears eager to avoid a more disruptive trade dispute with Brussels. China will likely seek tariff reductions on other goods as part of future rounds of trade talks and may not be as accommodating to EU import quotas on other items.

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